Chapter 7

Circles

> Restorative justice provides an opportunity for empowerment – *your* voice can be heard.
>
> Primary Learning Support Assistant

Sitting in a circle with members of one's community, most of whom share a common interest in restoring harmony, care, safety and respect to that community, is the starting point for many restorative practices. Advocates of restorative justice draw inspiration from Native American peacemaking circles and the community problem-solving traditions of Maori peoples in New Zealand (Johnston 2002). However large or small the circle, the principles remain the same.

This chapter considers the place of circles in a whole school approach to restorative justice. It begins by suggesting that regular circles, across the school community, form the seedbed from which can grow the restorative skills and approaches described in the book so far. Restorative justice works best when there is a commitment to community, where there is already mutual respect, a willingness to listen to each other, a need to belong and be included. This cannot be taken for granted in any modern community and cannot be taken for granted in a school. In order to have a community, and relationships that people want to restore, we need to work to create that community in the first place, and the relatively discrete community of the school is an ideal environment to start.

The chapter advocates regular circles for every part of the school community and describes the different roles the circle can play. It considers the community building potential of circles as well as its uses when there are problems to solve in groups or even large group conflict.

Circle time

Working in circles in the UK is often given the name 'circle time' and has many enthusiastic advocates (e.g. Bliss *et al.* 1995; Kingston Friends Workshop Group; Mosley and Tew 1999). These people have produced excellent books full of

ideas and activities to support the busy teacher wanting to develop a circle time approach. It is not my intention to duplicate some already excellent resources. My intention in this chapter is draw out the links between circle work and restorative practice. I would argue that the skills and ethos of restorative practice can be developed in a school through circles and that without regular circles it will be difficult to maintain the ethos vital to successful restorative work. Although the writers mentioned above suggest circle time for staff and students alike, most of the ideas in their books tends to be for use with young people. I cannot emphasise strongly enough that a whole school restorative approach relies on every member of the school community having the opportunity to meet regularly in a circle with their peers and to develop together the skills and ethos required to develop a strong, supportive school and team spirit. From this 'restorative seedbed', processes such as mediation, restorative debriefing, conferencing, restorative discipline procedures and win-win problem solving develop naturally. Without such a seedbed the processes mentioned above are merely tools – with no well-nourished roots and no sustainability.

Circle time is a popular process used in primary schools and, increasingly, in secondary schools. It provides an opportunity for people to come together in a safe, supportive and enjoyable way to learn more about each other, to grow together as a team, to develop communication skills, to share exploration of problems and to celebrate achievements. Participants are able to develop their social, moral and emotional skills and develop a sense of shared purpose. In process and content circle time embodies the spirit of inclusion and develops active citizenship skills.

Using games, pair and group activities, circle time can help to develop self-esteem, appreciation of others, listening skills, problem solving, co-operation and a sense of fun. It is not just an educational and enjoyable experience for young people, however. All members of a school community can use this process to enhance their working relationships – whole staff teams, senior management, lunchtime controllers, governors, to name but a few.

In my experience however, not enough time is spent on developing the safety and trust in a circle before embarking on some of the wider applications of circles, such as conflict management, team building, personal and social education and emotional literacy development. I have seen young people attempt some potentially risky discussions without firm guidelines in place and without the safety needed for a certain amount of disclosure. Circle time is not a therapy session. However, well run, it can provide a forum for sharing worries and problems in a relatively safe way. For such a forum to work, the facilitator needs to know what they are doing and have clear guidelines and boundaries in place.

I would maintain that circle time needs to be underpinned by the same principles and values that underpin all restorative approaches. The guidelines in the

following boxes are essentially the ones I offer to those embarking on circle time for the first time.

Circle time – Guiding principles for running a good session

- Circle time is, above all, fun. Never forget the games! Laughing and playing together builds trust and a sense of belonging.
- Circle time is developmental – the skills required to make the most of the circle are learned by taking part.
- Sitting in a circle, on chairs of the same height, in an airy room where there will be no interruptions or people doing other things, is, for me, essential. Everyone can then feel included and the focus of attention is into the circle.
- The facilitator encourages everyone to take responsibility for the smooth running of the session by asking them to identify some simple guidelines that they will need to take part. This would be a session in itself if your group has not already done this.
- The facilitator is not responsible for the 'discipline' of the group once the rules have been negotiated: everyone in the group is. If someone is unable to respect the rules I would stop the session, explain I was feeling uneasy and ask how everyone else is feeling (as a 'go-round') and then ask for ways forward. I would encourage respect for the feelings of those who appear 'disruptive' and endeavour to offer alternatives to the circle if it is proving challenging for them. (Reprimands and sanctions are not congruent with the spirit of circle time, to my mind.)
- Everyone has the right to 'pass' on a go-round or a game. No one must feel under pressure to contribute, but in time most people feel safe to do so. This may take weeks though. Sitting in the room but not in the circle would not be an option as far as I am concerned, however. Do you have a colleague who could welcome someone who really does not want to join in at all?
- The facilitator says as little as possible. Making a comment after each contribution by a participant is an abuse of power! Encourage participants to deliver their comments to the circle, not to you. A talking stick highlights how often any one person talks – it certainly shuts *me* up!

Restorative value base for running circle time

- A commitment to mutual respect, which means that all 'put-downs' are discouraged, and challenged if made. (It is vital that the facilitator keeps positive and respectful at all times to model this, however frustrated they may feel!)
- An acknowledgement that we have the right to feel what we feel. There are no 'shoulds' and 'shouldn'ts' about feelings. A feeling is a feeling – but we might need to think about how we express the feeling in order to be heard.
- An acceptance of the right of others to a different point of view even if we disagree with it.
- An openness to working with people we may not usually work with, so we can develop tolerance of diversity, even in our own classroom or staff room.
- A commitment to respecting our differences and celebrating our shared experiences.
- An awareness of the shared responsibility for the good running of the session.
- An acceptance of the shared responsibility for including everyone and a sensitivity to each other's feelings about feeling excluded.
- An understanding by everyone that not being able to respect circle time rules is not being 'naughty' , 'disruptive' or 'unhelpful', but evidence that a need is not being met and something else is required to enable that need to be met.
- A belief that the content and process of circle time need to be congruent so that what we are saying and what we are doing fit!

To emphasise just how valuable this process is for adults I would invite readers to imagine what a team or department meeting would be like if it were run as described above. My suspicion is that we have all had experiences of meetings being dominated by people who talk too much, imposing their views on others without due regard for their views and feelings, and with the real views of the quiet ones only being expressed afterwards, between clenched teeth, in small groups in the cloakroom or the pub.

Readers may balk at beginning team meetings with games, and of course these are not always necessary. However, a sense of fun and a relaxed, safe atmosphere is often important, and I have run many circle time training sessions in which the feedback suggested that the games helped the staff to achieve this – a rare opportunity. Of course the rationale in such circumstances was always that staff needed to play the games themselves to be able to play them with their students, but I know from experience that adults will benefit personally as well.

Circle time acknowledges the importance of feelings, yet this side of ourselves is all too often deemed unprofessional in meetings. Nevertheless, if we are unable to express what we are feeling it leaks out in other ways. Restorative communication emphasises the need to be able to express what we are feeling and what we need in a way that is heard, without it being destructive or harmful. In the early stages of using circles for meetings this may not always be easy, but providing time is taken to acquire the skills, the meetings can only get better. This is what is meant by the principle of learning through taking part.

The values and principles underpin the circle experience and need to be understood and modelled by the facilitator in the first instance. However, the management of the circle process needs to belong to the participants, which is why negotiating guidelines at an early stage is vital.

In Chapter 2 I described how to negotiate guidelines in an introductory meeting about restorative principles. I use the same process with adults and children alike at the beginning of a circle time programme.

As mentioned in Chapter 2, the guidelines, or rules, grow from people's need for well-being and safety. Not only is everyone consulted and their views heard, but seeing the rules in terms of well-being helps people to see that breaking a rule will, by definition, impact on somebody's well-being. In other words, our actions have an impact on others. If we have a need, and some would argue a right, to feel safe, then we have a responsibility to maintain that right for others too.

Negotiating guidelines at the beginning of a year

Young people, and indeed people in general, engage more readily with rules or guidelines that they have developed themselves and for which they can see a point. Once the guidelines have been agreed it is easier to see that breaking a rule does have a significant impact on the well-being of others in the group. This is a first stage in encouraging young people to see that each action is behaviour with an impact and that we have choices about how we act. I hope it goes without saying that the guidelines established by the group apply equally to the adults working with the group. Adult teams may wish to develop their own guidelines and the same procedure described in Chapter 2 works well with them too.

The point to make is that these are the things we need, as a group, to work at our best. If we are not getting them, then we are not working at our best. The responsibility of the group is to ensure that everyone is giving each other what they need.

Working with the groundrules in circle time

The groundrules need constant review – they are the mission statement of the group for working harmoniously together. Preventing conflict is preferable to picking up the pieces afterwards – although every conflict is an opportunity for learning conflict management, so it is not desirable to avoid conflict all together! In Chapter 2 I suggested a simple sentence completion activity; this can be used repeatedly, over several weeks, concentrating on a different guideline each week to help the group realise what they all need from each other. Examples of sentences to pass round:

I don't feel respected when...
I do feel respected when...

I don't feel safe when...
I do feel safe when...

I don't feel valued when...
I do feel valued when...

I have picked these examples because the need to feel respected, to feel safe and to feel valued are some of the more common needs on a list.

The facilitator generally starts the activity. In this way they are taking the first risk, not asking people to do anything they are not willing to do themselves and modelling the nature of the contribution. Another circle time convention is that no one has to contribute, and so the right to pass is introduced early on. If a talking stick is being used for this activity then it can simply be held for a short spell and passed on, or the word 'pass' can be said. It is always a good idea to go round a second time because often people who passed on the first round have had time to think and can now contribute. There is no pressure, however. Sometimes a 'pass' can mean someone has nothing to say or is not in the mood to take part at that moment. The emphasis is on feeling safe at all times, since it is only when we feel safe that we can take risks.

Doing this sentence completion activity regularly highlights the different needs we have, even though we seem to be asking for the same thing. 'Support' from one person can feel like 'interference' by another, for example. It also helps young people develop a practical repertoire of things they can do to meet the needs of others. The guideline 'valuing each other' becomes more meaningful when we know that a teacher, for example, loves to be thanked for an interesting lesson or a shy student is thrilled to be greeted by her name. It can lead to some

very practical changes in behaviour that no one has really given much thought to before.

One staff group was struck by the idea that they all need to feel valued and respected and yet had a staff room in which everyone had their own personally labelled jars of tea and coffee. Somebody suggested that they adopted a system of shared refreshments and that on the wall, by the kettle, should be a list of everyone's tea and coffee needs. In this way, when one person saw another in need of a 'cuppa' they knew exactly what drink to make and whether milk and sugar were required. This suggestion made a significant impact on the feeling of staff solidarity and care.

Rule making through game playing

When working with younger groups and people with short concentration spans I suggest playing games straight away, and introducing the idea of guidelines through the games. Explain a game and then ask if any rules are needed for the game to work (e.g. if it involves swapping chairs, what rules might there need to be to make it safe?). Once a few rules have been suggested, ask if everyone agrees. After the game, review whether people were able to stick to the rules or if any more were needed. Maybe try the game again. Variations on the game could also be suggested and tried out. Important questions include:

- How can we ensure people do not feel left out?
- Is the game safe or might someone get hurt?
- How can we mix up boys and girls?
- Is this game possible for all abilities in the room? Do we need to make adjustments so it can be? (For example, swapping seats is difficult for someone in a wheelchair.)

Listening to everyone's contribution is vital, so early on you may need to ask students what they need from each other to be able to take part in discussions. Whenever you ask for contributions it may be worth considering asking students to work in pairs before inviting contributions in the open circle. Speaking out is daunting, and sharing some ideas with a partner beforehand builds confidence. It also ensures that everyone gets their ideas heard by someone, even if they do not get a chance to talk in the wider circle.

Respecting the guidelines

At some point someone will raise the question about what happens if the guidelines are forgotten or ignored by someone. If the school is deciding to embrace a restorative approach in dealing with rule transgression then the response is straightforward. What is at stake is that by failing to adhere to one of the rules,

others have been adversely affected. Clearly the way forward is for those affected to meet and hear from each other how the situation has impacted on them and for all sides to agree an acceptable way forward. This approach takes time so here are some quick suggestions for dealing with problems as they occur.

1. Respond at once by expressing how the situation has affected you and what you need to move on and then by asking the other people involved what happened from their perspective and what they want to happen. This can often lead to a quick resolution with no residual bad feeling.

2. In the middle of a circle time lesson this approach can be widened out to the whole class to great effect because it demonstrates how thoughtless behaviour in a room is likely to have an effect on most people in the room.

Try using a 'go-round' starting with yourself:

When someone talks loudly during the lesson I feel angry because...'

Then invite all the circle to complete the same sentence. Be prepared for some not to feel the same way as you!

Now go round again and maybe start with what you would like to happen in general terms but without making practical suggestions at this stage. See what comes from them, and in particular those whose behaviour has been causing you distress. You are appealing to their better nature – this is a 'no-blame approach' in action:

What I would like to happen is...

I have found this approach can help all the class to take the responsibility for the smooth running of the lesson and have not needed to use it very often.

3. Failing this, arrange for a longer conversation with those involved after a lesson when tempers have cooled and people have had time to reflect. Be prepared to hear the reasons behind the behaviour and what the students needed that they were not getting at the time. Explore with them how these needs could be met in a different way and encourage reflection on how to deal with a similar situation next time in a way that does not cause you or them distress.

Remember the emphasis all the time is on:

- What is the meaning behind the behaviour?
- Who has been affected by the behaviour?
- What was everyone feeling and thinking then and now?
- How can the harm caused be repaired?

- How can the matter be put right as far as possible to everyone's satisfaction and so that people's needs can be met?
- What can be done to avoid the same situation happening again?

4. Sometimes conflicts flare up between others when you are not directly involved. In such situations mediation might be required. Circle time is the foundation of effective mediation, sharing the value base of mutual respect, listening to all sides, being non-judgemental and respecting that those in a difficult situation are often the best ones to resolve it.

The key point is that if the guidelines are for everyone, then ways need to be found for dealing with rule breaking that are acceptable and useful for everyone involved. Naming, blaming, shaming and punishing need not come into such an approach and might not be welcome by the adults in any case! (And never were welcomed by young people.)

A circle time structure

A great deal of time has been spent discussing the negotiation and reviewing of guidelines for the group, because in essence the circle time experience is *about* being in a group and community building.

Every activity, even the most playful, is an experience of being with others and interacting in a positive way. Every experience shared in the group is an opportunity for learning more about human interaction. If someone feels left out, or that their opinion is being ignored, then review of the activity in which this happens allows for people to hear how that experience feels, and whether they have contributed to it.

However, the circle time programme needs careful thought if it is to be an enjoyable experience for everyone and not become too much like navel-gazing. My guiding principles come from the iceberg/mountain model considered in Chapter 2, with its underpinning values of high self-esteem, affirmation of others, communication and co-operation. At the end of a circle time session everyone will, ideally:

- feel better about themselves
- feel better about each other
- have had an opportunity to express themselves
- have had an opportunity to listen to one another
- have worked or played together co-operatively
- have reflected on what they have learnt and enjoyed.

The programme needs to create opportunities for as much of this to happen as possible. I would argue that in a restorative school, striving for the mountain rather than the iceberg, these aims would be written into every lesson.

A circle time session might comprise:

- **A gathering** – a go-round in the circle when everyone makes a very small contribution, maybe completing a sentence suggested by the facilitator.
- **A mixer** – a game that ensures everyone mixes up and sits with people they do not usually work with.
- A slightly longer **focus activity** on a particular theme (listening skills? negotiation skills? planning? private reflection and drawing? citizenship issues?).
- **A review** of what has been learned as a circle go-round or in pairs.
- **Another game** if time – preferably a co-operative one.
- **A closing** – 'One thing I have enjoyed this time…'

The type of circle described above can be fitted in to most busy weeks, either as part of the literacy hour, since it undoubtedly supports language work, or as part of the citizenship and PHSE (pastoral, health and social education) programme or in the tutorial slot most secondary schools allow for. The time is valuable for creating a sense of belonging in a class group and encouraging them to develop an ethos of care and responsibility towards one another.

It lays the ground for developing the restorative skills described earlier in the book, and most training in such skills is run using the circle format.

Problem-solving circles

There are times when a particular issue or a problem facing a group needs to be discussed. If a group is used to circle conventions and feels safe to talk in this way, then circle process is ideal at such a time. The facilitator 'holds' the circle, ensuring everyone has a chance to have their say, perhaps passing round a talking stick.

If emotions start to run high then the facilitator will use such skills from restorative enquiry, mediation and conferencing as they feel are relevant.

Problem-solving circles might be used by:

- governors
- teaching staff
- parent groups
- learning support teams

- lunchtime teams
- school councils
- class groups
- sports teams.

The list is endless. The only point to make is that such groups are unlikely to be very successful if the members of the circle only meet when there is a crisis. There are schools in Berkshire that regularly start the day with a staff circle, so that everyone can check in on each other, share problems and ask for support if required. One school invited me in to run a circle for staff just before an OFSTED inspection. Fears were shared, help was asked for and offered, and people spoke later of how helpful it had been. Perhaps all teachers need regular circles to get themselves through an inspection.

Again in Berkshire there are plans to extend the existing circle time programme, which focuses on the children, to include adults' circles for parents and others for learning support assistants. The aim is to develop the confidence and assertiveness of such groups so they can have a real voice in the school.

Community conferences

To some extent, a community conference is similar to a problem-solving circle. Once again the words are not necessarily important. What is important is the ability of the facilitator to be flexible, and use the skills required by the situation. In the school context a community conference might be used when there are conflicts developing between large groups of young people or there is disharmony in a class group, a staff team or amongst parents.

The facilitator would be using circle conventions, while mindful of the conference structure and the need for everyone to express their thoughts, feelings and needs once they have told their own story. In large groups it would be usual for facilitators to work in teams of at least two.

There are no rigid guidelines for such processes. Small group discussion might need to precede the large group meeting; break-out meetings might need to be held during the meeting. Preparation beforehand will of course be vital, as will a clear set of guidelines at the outset. Nevertheless the skills of restorative enquiry and the strength of the circle will provide the keys to a successful outcome.

Family group conferences

The use of family group conferences as part of the restorative jigsaw in a school is being pioneered in Hampshire. They are a different type of problem-solving circle but rely on the key restorative values of empowerment, inclusion and the

belief that those with the problems are best placed to resolve these problems. They can be used whenever the behaviour of a young person is causing concern and it is felt that the wider family network could be useful in supporting the young person. More often than not, in such circumstances, the immediate family group is in need of wider support. The co-ordinator of the conference (in Hampshire these are from the local education authority) spends time communicating with the immediate family, the young person themselves and whoever this person identifies as potential sources of support. Family members and friends of the family are helped, financially and practically, with travel to the venue for the conference, which is usually a neutral venue chosen by the family as suitable for their needs. Professionals with concerns about the young person are also invited to the meeting.

Initially the coordinator chairs the meeting and time is allowed for the professionals to raise their concerns about the young person and for the family to ask questions. After this the co-ordinator and the professionals leave the room and the family are left to agree a plan for the young person's care and protection, and also decide how this plan will be reviewed and what to do if any part of the plan is not carried out.

When the plan has been agreed the co-ordinator and the professionals return, the plan is recorded and resources are negotiated. A plan would only be rejected if it was felt that the young person was being put at risk (see Morris and Tunnard 1996).

There are many different situations in which this variation on the restorative conference process can be used in the school context. Examples include in the event of non-attendance or when a young person's behaviour looks likely to lead to exclusion.

Case study – A problem-solving circle

An early experience of discovering the power of circles took place when I was the tutor of a Year 7 group at an inner-city comprehensive many years ago now. The school was on the edge of the city, in an area that was predominantly white. Most of the students came from council estates and were friendly, street-wise and good-natured in their tolerance of the teaching staff who were, after all, doing their best!

At the beginning of the school year I put aside the tutorial programme I had been given to follow for the first few weeks of the term. Instead, I concentrated on giving the young people the task of working out for themselves how we might organise the sessions in such a way that everyone could have their say and feel listened to. We negotiated groundrules but also, importantly, the class discussed the best seating plan for such activities. It took several tutor periods for them all to agree, and they chose a circle format. Not as I would have liked – normally it would have involved moving the desks aside every time; however, seating places were aranged around the outside of the room, leaving desks as they were, so that some people sat on desks, some on chairs and, from a bird's-eye view, a circle shape was approximated and everyone felt included.

The whole process took many weeks, and a lot of trust had been developed over this time. They had learnt to respect each other's views and appreciated that I was sharing power and responsibility with them. The space must have felt safe enough for Leroy to decide to share his problems with the group. A boy of about 12, Leroy was a likeable, extrovert lad who certainly made his presence felt in every class. His energy level and mischievous nature did not find favour with everyone and he was beginning to get into quite a lot of trouble. What his classmates and I had not appreciated was that he was also coming in for some targeting from other students because of his colour, and possibly for his challenging behaviour.

I cannot remember if he was the only black child in the school, but he was certainly in a tiny minority. My suspicion is that he had developed a rather larger-than-life persona to cope with this situation, which was also the same at his junior school. Be that as it may, he poured out his troubles to his classmates who listened respectfully. And then they took it in turns to explain to Leroy how they experienced his behaviour towards them.

Leroy heard how they did not always appreciate the way he spoke to them, or the way he handled situations at times. Gradually, during this extraordinary tutor group session, the whole class negotiated how they would support and stand by Leroy in the playground and in lessons if he, in turn, tempered his own behaviour towards them. Everyone acknowledged that no one deserved to be the butt of racism, and all of them were more than happy to help Leroy challenge this, but they were also clear that his troubles were not always necessarily caused by racist attitudes.

The issues that were raised were complex – but these were Year 7 students speaking from the heart, and what they resolved together was brave and honest. Leroy left the room walking six foot high, and this was very important. He had felt heard, and so had everyone else. I was moved, and very, very humbled.

Summary

This chapter has described the various uses of circles in the school context. It has made a case for circles being at the centre of a whole school restorative approach and the conventions of the circle becoming the way a school does business.

It has described how the increasingly popular technique of 'circle time' fits into the restorative jigsaw and differentiates between this more formalised process and circles held to address problems and concerns. Both have their place in the timetable of students and staff alike.

Meeting in a circle is the starting point for every restorative process, whether it is a circle of three or 20. Meeting in circles regularly can provide an opportunity for every member of the school community to:

- recognise their role in that community
- take responsibility for the impact of their actions on everyone else in the community
- be supported by that community
- work together in resolving any problems people have in the community
- celebrate belonging to that community.

This chapter has explored different applications of circles, ways of establishing safety through groundrules and ways of addressing conflicts when they occur in the circle.

In the next two chapters, which look at issues of implementation and sustainability, circles remain at the heart of the process.

Part III

Implementation and Sustainability